

CHILD'S PLAY
Children competing in *fugdi*, a folk game of Chhattisgarh, during the multi-sport event

BHUPESH KESHARWANI

of being ignored by the state unit. The Olympics are being held at six levels. The state government has created and funded Rajiv Yuva Mitaan (young friends) clubs at the lowest level—gram panchayat in rural areas and ward in urban pockets. There are 11,664 such clubs in villages and 1,605 in towns and cities, each having nominated members. Needless to say, the 'young, friendly' Congress workers associated with these clubs are the ones organising the games at the grassroots.

The Congress is also expecting the games to serve as an outreach to all sections of voters, be it youth, women or even children, who will be the electorate of the future. All events are open to both genders in three age categories: under 18 years, 18-40 years, and 40 years and above. Local officials say the response has been more encouraging among women than men. "It's an opportunity for them (women) to get out of their homes, take leave of their daily chores for some time," says a senior municipal officer in Raipur.

According to the state sports department, the second level of Chhattisgarhia Olympics (zonal in urban areas and cluster in rural) will see the participation of about 3.2 million people across various categories and disciplines. In a state with an estimated population of 30 million, it translates to a participation upwards of 10 per cent of the people. After moving through the three levels, the winners from rural and urban areas will meet each other at the district level.

THE FOLK GAMES

- *Gilli danda* (tip-cat)
- *Pitthul* (seven stones)
- *Sankhli* (chain tag)
- *Langdi daud* (one-legged race)
- *Banti* (marbles)
- *Gedi daud* (bamboo stilt race)
- *Bhanwara* (spinning top)
- *Billas* (hopscotch)
- *Rassakashi* (tug of war)
- *Fugdi*, kabaddi & kho kho

(Long jump and 100-metre dash are also a part of the event)

Divisional games will follow, and then the state finals from December 28, 2022, to January 6, 2023.

JUST FOR SHOW?

Even as the state government makes tall claims about citizen participation, the Opposition BJP has termed the event a "waste of time and resources". The accidental deaths of two participants—a 32-year-old man from Raigarh district and 28-year-old woman from Kondagaon—during kabaddi matches have also handed the Opposition more ammunition to target the government. The families of both the deceased have been awarded Rs 4 lakh each, but the BJP has demanded better compensation.

"I have nothing against traditional sports, but when the entire country is preparing athletes for internationally recognised games, why is the Chhattisgarh government being so regressive?" asks Sunil Soni, Lok Sabha member from Raipur. The BJP leader also questions the Rajiv Yuva Mitaan clubs. "Are they government bodies? How are they being given government funds? How will they be accounted for?"

The state government in its budget for 2022-23 has allocated Rs 75 crore to set up these clubs, with each eligible to get Rs 1 lakh annually. They have already been given Rs 25,000 towards incidental expenses during the Olympics. Overall, the sports department estimates expenses of Rs 5-15 lakh per district, depending on the number of clubs, and Rs 20 lakh at the divisional level. The state-level event is estimated to cost the exchequer Rs 5 crore, and the total outlay for the three-month extravaganza is upward of Rs 10 crore.

The players are not expected to spend any money. The government claims all their expenses will be covered. The prize money, however, is modest. For instance, the state champions in team events will get just Rs 10,000 while the individual event winners will take home a paltry Rs 1,000. The idea behind the games, say sports department officials, is not to make people participate in them for the money, but for team-building, creating awareness about sports and providing a platform to common citizens to take part in them.

That said, where does Chhattisgarh figure in the country's sporting hierarchy? Not too high up, if one goes by its medal tally in the recently concluded 36th National Games. Athletes from the state won just two gold, five silver and six bronze medals, with the state ending in 22nd place out of 37 overall. Meanwhile, the government has allocated Rs 2.83 crore this fiscal to set up a Mallakhamb Academy in Narayanpur district to nurture the traditional Indian form of gymnastics. Amid the tug-of-war for prominence between traditional sports and modern games, it is to be seen who will pip the other to a podium finish. Or, will all the effort be nothing more than a contest for political oneupmanship? ■